

Yi Baishi 依白饰 Backstory



She used to believe ink could hold a soul in place. Eight strokes, no more, and a whole cosmology sat still on the page – obedient, legible, hers. That was the life before: the scriptorium at dawn, cypress and ink-stone, a brush lifted the way other women lift a child from a cradle, carefully, as though it might wake and cry.

It did not wake. It was taken.

She does not say the friend's name anymore, not even to herself, not even in the dark. But she sees her sometimes – in the tilt of a rank, the cut of a robe glimpsed at a distance, the particular way certain doors now open for people who were once, like Yi Baishi, merely promising. She has never proven it. She has never disproven it either. There is no ceremony for a wound that will not close because no one will say what caused it, and Yi Baishi has learned to live inside that unfinished sentence the way a stray learns to live inside a doorway – not sheltered, exactly. Just out of the worst of the rain.

The Dao does not grasp, she copied out once, a hundred times, in her own hand, as if repetition were a kind of forgiveness she could earn from herself. She believed it, mostly. She still tries to.

The Silver Needles took her back without asking her to explain herself and with no obligation, and there was mercy in that – a mercy so plain it almost hurt more than cruelty would have. Her aunt and mentor there says little and notices everything, the way water notices a crack in stone: patiently, and without malice, simply by finding it. Yi Baishi has spent long evenings beside her, not speaking, letting the silence do what neither of them has words for.

Now it is a clinic to the south of Apricot Village in the outskirts of Kaifeng, and the smell of crushed mugwort instead of ink, and hands that used to shape characters shaping poultices instead, pressing warmth into the ribs of a boy who fell from a roof, or coaxing fever out of an old woman who calls her xiaomei – little sister – though Yi Baishi has not felt like anyone's little anything in a very long time. She laughs with them. She means it. That is perhaps the strangest part: none of the warmth is performance. It is only that the warmth has learned to travel outward and never back in, like a river carved to flow one direction only, no matter how the land tilts.

Ask her about herself and watch what happens. The question lands soft as a coin in water – a small splash, a ring of attention, and then it sinks, and she is already laughing about something else, already refilling your cup, already asking after your mother's cough. People leave her company feeling seen and go home unable to say a single true thing about who she is. She has gotten very good at this. Good enough that most don't notice the door was never opened at all.

At night it is different. At night the doctrine that reads so cleanly in the texts gets harder to hold, the way a smooth stone gets harder to hold the longer you clench it. She has sat with the dying. She has held hands going cold and said the peaceful things one says, about the ten thousand things arising and passing, about how nothing is truly lost, only changed – and some nights she believes every word, and some nights the words are just sounds she is making so the room won't be silent. The gap between knowing a teaching and living it: she has come to think this gap is where most of a life actually happens. Not in the temple. In the gap.

Robin Piāo 飄 circles the infirmary courtyard some evenings, restless the way she gets restless, black wings catching the last orange light before it goes. He was hers before Apricot Village, before the fall even – one of the few things the Order never touched, because a familiar cannot be dismissed from a post it was never granted by anyone but the bond itself. He watches her the way her mentor watches water: for the crack. When he lands on her shoulder uninvited, she has learned it usually means she has gone somewhere in her head that she should be pulled back from.

This is who arrives, eventually, at the edges of Baoyu's circle – not quite whole, certainly not healed. A woman mid-fall who has simply gotten skilled at falling gracefully, who laughs easily and holds herself carefully and has not stopped, in five years, turning the same unanswerable question over and over like a stone worn smooth from handling. She brings warmth wherever she goes and takes almost none of it home with her. She brings a bird who watches for cracks. She brings a discipline of the hand that has quietly, without her noticing, become a discipline of holding herself together instead of holding a brush.

What she is looking for, if you asked her – and she would deflect, and then, if you were patient, if you waited past the deflection the way her mentor waits past silence – what she is looking for is simply somewhere the unfinished sentence can finally end. Not vengeance. She does not think she wants vengeance, though she has never fully trusted that thought either. Just an ending. Just permission to stop carrying a door in her chest that opens onto a room she was never allowed to see the inside of.

Until then: mugwort and ink-memory, a laughing mouth and a locked one, a winged watcher on her shoulder, and the long work of learning to want less than certainty and still call it peace.